

Email Campaign Metrics and Operations Guide

Study notes for email campaign operations and reporting

1. Key campaign metrics

Metric	Definition and formula
Open rate	Percentage of delivered emails that were opened. Formula: unique opens / delivered x 100.
Click-through rate (CTR)	Percentage of delivered emails that received a click. Formula: unique clicks / delivered x 100.
Bounce rate	Percentage of sent emails that were not delivered. Formula: bounces / sent x 100.
Unsubscribe rate	Percentage of delivered emails that led to an unsubscribe. Formula: unsubscribes / delivered x 100.
Complaint rate	Percentage of delivered emails marked as spam. Formula: complaints / delivered x 100.
EPC (earnings per click)	Average revenue earned for each click. Formula: total revenue / total clicks.
CPM (cost per mille)	Cost, or in publisher terms revenue, per 1,000 emails sent or delivered. Formula: cost / emails x 1,000.
Revenue	Total income generated by the campaign, from conversions, leads or sales attributed to it.
Revenue growth	Change in revenue compared with a previous period. Formula: (current revenue - previous revenue) / previous revenue x 100.

Example: a campaign delivers 100,000 emails, gets 20,000 opens and 2,000 clicks, and earns 3,000 dollars. The open rate is 20 percent, the CTR is 2 percent and the EPC is 1.50 dollars. If the sending cost was 200 dollars, the CPM is $200 / 100,000 \times 1,000 = 2$ dollars.

Note on open rates: automatic image loading features such as mail privacy protection inflate open counts for some recipients, so clicks, conversions and revenue are more reliable indicators of real engagement than opens alone.

2. Dashboards and reporting

A campaign dashboard normally shows trends by day, by ISP (Gmail, Yahoo, Outlook and others), by sending domain, by IP and by offer. The questions a dashboard should answer are: Which ISPs have falling open rates or rising bounces? Which domains or IPs produce the best EPC? Is revenue growing week over week and what drives it? Comparing open rate, EPC, CPM and revenue together prevents wrong conclusions, because a high open rate with a low EPC may mean the audience is engaged but the offer is weak.

3. Daily campaign operations workflow

- Prepare the audience: apply suppression lists, remove hard bounces and complainers, and segment by engagement.
- Validate the sending setup: confirm the domain's SPF, DKIM and DMARC records and check the IP and domain assigned to the campaign.
- Schedule and throttle the send per ISP so that volume matches each ISP's tolerance and the IP's warm-up stage.

- Monitor in real time: delivery, deferrals, bounces and complaints, using the in-house monitoring application and ISP tools.
- Troubleshoot issues such as deferrals, blocks or spam placement by checking logs, authentication, blocklists and ISP-specific data.
- Report results: update dashboards for opens, clicks, EPC, CPM and revenue, and write down findings and next actions.

4. Working with different ISPs

Each ISP applies its own filtering rules and limits. Gmail relies heavily on engagement and domain reputation, and publishes a spam rate in Postmaster Tools. Yahoo uses complaint feedback loops and reputation by domain and IP. Outlook and Hotmail use SNDS and complaint data and are sensitive to sudden volume changes. Because behaviour differs, results should always be analysed per ISP rather than only as one total.

5. Bulk sender requirements

Major mailbox providers have introduced requirements for senders who send large volumes. Typical requirements include: authenticating mail with SPF and DKIM, publishing a DMARC policy, keeping the From domain aligned, supporting one-click unsubscribe for promotional mail, honouring unsubscribe requests quickly, and keeping the spam complaint rate low. Requirements and thresholds change over time, so always confirm the current rules in each provider's official documentation.

6. Quick troubleshooting table

Symptom	Likely causes	First checks
Sudden drop in open rate at one ISP	Spam placement or throttling at that ISP	Placement test, authentication, ISP complaint data
Rising bounce rate	Old or low quality list, invalid addresses	Hard bounce codes, list source, validation
Many deferrals (4xx codes)	Sending too fast for the ISP or a new IP	Slow the send rate, review warm-up plan
Rejections (5xx codes) mentioning policy or reputation	Blocklist or poor reputation	Blocklist checkers, postmaster tools, content review
High opens but low EPC	Weak offer or wrong audience	Segment and offer analysis, landing page review
DMARC failures in reports	Unaligned sender or unknown sending source	Aggregate reports, SPF and DKIM alignment